



Top Dogs

By Anna Kirschberg



Book Summary

This non-fiction book uses vibrant, modern photography and includes images of service dogs and the various activities they help humans with. What makes a top dog? Vivid photographs depict and help the text explain some basic information about each page image.

This book follows the Beanstalk Books (Letters & Sounds) Phase 2 progression and focuses on learning the first 19 letters that are taught in this sequence.

Skills and Strategies

This book builds on decodable reading strategies for high/low readers. The book has been written using a strictly controlled vocabulary. Text uses only **decodable regular words** (according to the week by week progression of Letters & Sounds) along with 'Heart Words' or 'Common Exception Words' (CEWs). Heart Words are frequently used words that are not decodable at this phase.

Phase 2 - Letter Sounds

s	a	t	p	i	n	m	d
g	o	c	k	ck	e	u	r
h	b	f	ff	l	ll	ss	

Heart Words:

go

This book also supports other key reading strategies:

- Recognising the relationship between words and images;
- Pointing one-to-one at each word to ensure an appropriate match;
- Vocabulary and word study.

This book also supports key comprehension strategies:

- Making connections between prior knowledge and the text;
- Summarising the main ideas.

This book also supports non-fiction strategies:

- Gaining information from photographs;
- Encountering curriculum related terms and concepts.

Introducing the Text

Open up the discussion about the front cover image and make connections with the children's prior knowledge of this topic. Prompt discussions by using the vocabulary in the book.

What does the title of the book tell you about the front cover image?

Describe the image on the front cover.

Read the title and the name of the author to the group. Read aloud any heart words from the front inner cover.

Reading the Text

Page 2 – Explain where to begin reading, and ask the student to point to each word as you read aloud together. Sound out the letter sounds as you go, for example: (/t/o/p/). On this page, the photograph shows a service dog.

Page 3 – Explain that in this photograph, the image shows a surf life saver and his dog sitting on the beach (/s/i/t/, /d/o/g/).

Page 4 – This photograph shows a rescue dog digging in the snow (/d/i/g/).

Page 5 – This photograph depicts a dog surfing (/d/o/g). Note the heart word 'go' on this page.

Page 6 – This photograph shows a guide dog with its owner. How is the guide dog helping him? Sound out the words as you read together (/m/a/n/).

Page 7 – This photograph shows a young girl in a hospital being visited by a care dog. Sound out the words as you read together (/k/i/d/).

Page 8 - This photograph shows a statue of a firefighter with his service dog. Discuss.

Children can now read the book independently.

At the end of the book, go over the text and photographs again and discuss what is happening on each page.

Revisiting the Text

As a group, refer back to the table in the front inner cover and identify the words in the book that use the new letter sounds being taught in Phase 2.

To start with, identify as many new consonant and / or vowel graphemes as you can in the words in the text. For example, 'd', 'o', 'g', in the word 'dog'. Sound out the letter sounds to say the word together; /d/o/g/.

Following Up

Use the BLM for this story, the students can learn more about the introduction of the new letter sounds being used in the text of the story.